How to Talk to Your Mom



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Your mom says one thing, and suddenly you're defending yourself like you're twelve again. Then you spend the entire evening replaying the conversation, feeling guilty and wishing it had gone differently.

Here are phrases adult daughters often hear from their less-than-perfect moms. We collected them from stories women have shared on forums, in letters to psychologists, and in messages to us. The follow-up exchanges illustrate how these conversations often unfold, because we know Mom rarely stops after just one remark.

> **Not every mom who says these things is a bad mother.**

This guide isn't about helping either of you win an argument. It's about helping you both come away from a conversation feeling a little warmer toward each other than usual—and perhaps a little closer.

This guide will help you express your position clearly while being considerate of your mom, avoid endless explanations and defenses, and choose a way of staying in touch that you can realistically manage.

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A Few General Rules for Talking to a Less-Than-Perfect Mom

> Always remember that you're an adult now. But your mom will always be your mom. Try not to take on the role of the parent when you talk to her; doing so can provoke conflict.

> Sometimes you can let a small jab slide: try not to dwell on it, respond gently to the point, and don't argue.

> When you suggest a time, ask whether it works for her.

> And when your mom is warm with you, respond with plenty of warmth—and stay in that moment a little longer.

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Quick Reference: Go-To Phrases

PHRASE	WHEN TO USE IT	IF MOM KEEPS GOING
"Sorry, Mom. I was thinking about this myself yesterday, but you beat me to it."	When Mom reproaches you, feels hurt, or asks, "Why didn't you call?"	Warmly and to the point: "I missed you too. How are you?"
"I need to think about that."	When she offers unsolicited advice about work, money, or your life	"Thanks for the suggestion. I'll think about it. Can you send me more information?" Don't promise a deadline.
"I really like it. But tell me how you see it." (Show interest in and respect for Mom's opinion. That doesn't mean you have to share her tastes.)	When she criticizes your hair, clothes, or home	"I really do like it, Mom. But I'll look up the options you mentioned online and check them out." Stay calm; don't argue.
"Thanks, Mom."	For a gift or advice you don't need	Don't debate it. You can decide later what to do with it.
"I can do Wednesday evening or Saturday afternoon. Which works better for you?" Always try to offer alternatives. Don't boss Mom around.	When Mom asks for more time and attention	Repeat when you're available, and follow through on what you agree.
"Mom, this conversation is hard for me. I love you, and I don't want us to fight."	Your husband, your weight, the past—when Mom starts going over the same issue again	Ask how she's doing. If that doesn't help, gently suggest talking another time.
"Mom, it's painful and uncomfortable for me to talk about this right now. Could we call each other tomorrow instead?"	An insult, or the third round of the same argument	Say goodbye warmly. Call the next day in your usual voice.

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1. COMMUNICATION AND ATTENTION

1.1 Complaints About How Often and How Long You Call

You haven't called much lately, and your mom sends reproachful texts or criticizes you when you finally call.

WHAT MOM SAYS

"Have you completely forgotten your mother?"

"Is it really that hard to pick up the phone and call me?"

"If I didn't call you, you'd never even think about me."

"You used to call, at least. Now you've disappeared completely."

"You couldn't find five minutes for your mother all week?"

"Well, look who remembered me... I was beginning to think no one cared whether I was alive or lying sick somewhere."

"Other daughters call their mothers every day to check on them... I'm the only one with children so cold and cruel to their own mother."

"You're alive? I'd almost forgotten what your voice sounds like."

"Is your phone only for talking to your friends?"

WHAT NOT TO SAY—AND WHY

✕ **Daughter:** "Mom, I haven't forgotten you! I'm swamped at work, and the kids have been sick. I'll definitely call as soon as I have time."

Why this doesn't help: You start justifying yourself and trying to prove you had a good enough reason not to call. But then the conversation becomes an argument about whether you're busy enough to have the right not to call your mother. Mom can easily dismiss every explanation: "Everyone works," "I raised children too," or "You can always find five minutes." You end up defending yourself more and more, while the conversation moves further away from any normal connection: "See? I told you, I'm just a nuisance. You don't care about your mother."

YOUR GOAL

Don't feel compelled to justify every day you didn't call, while also avoiding a fight and keeping the door open to communication.

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GO-TO PHRASES

Daughter	"Mom, I called because I missed you and wanted to talk. Tell me how you've been."
Mom	"Couldn't you have called sooner? I haven't heard a word from you in a week."
Daughter	"I know. I've missed you too. What's new?"
Mom	"You sure don't act like it. You have time for everybody except your mother."
Daughter	"Mom, do you want us to spend some time talking?"
Mom	"That's what I'm doing. So now I'm not allowed to say anything?"
Daughter	"You can tell me you missed me. I'd be happy to hear that. But when our conversation starts with complaints, it's hard for me to talk to you."
Mom	"Well, sorry I'm such a burden to you."
Daughter	"You're not a burden. I want to talk to you. How was your week?"

IF MOM KEEPS BLAMING YOU

Mom	"What's the point of telling you? You're not interested anyway."
Daughter	"I am interested. That's why I'm asking. But if you don't feel like talking right now, we can call each other another time."

♥ WHAT MOM COULD SAY OR TEXT INSTEAD

✓ **Mom:** "Hi, sweetheart. I've been feeling lonely today. Would you have time to call and tell me how you're doing? Or maybe you could stop by for tea? Bring the kids too. I'll bake their favorite pie."

♥ **You don't need to prove that you're busy enough to deserve a life of your own. You can love and miss your mom without calling her every day.**

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1.2 When Mom Expects You to Be Available to Talk Right Now

Mom calls at a bad time and insists on talking.

WHAT NOT TO SAY—AND WHY

✕ **Daughter, answering the call:** "Mom, I can't talk right now. I'm driving / at work / in a meeting. I'll definitely call you as soon as I'm free today."

Why this doesn't help: Mom gets used to you always being available to her.

WHAT MOM SAYS

"I called you three times. What could possibly be more important than your mother?"

"Why aren't you answering? What if something happened to me and I needed help?"

"Fine, fine, I won't keep you. Your mother always comes last anyway."

Your Goal: Stop flinching every time you see an incoming call from your mom.

✓ Prepare a few text templates for missed calls or messages from Mom: "Hi, Mom! I'm in a meeting right now—is it urgent? If you're okay, can I call you in an hour or two / after work?" Don't pick up when you know you can't give her 10–15 minutes of conversation. And don't answer if you're feeling emotionally unsettled at that moment.

GO-TO PHRASES

Mom (text)	"Where are you? You can't even spare one minute?"
You	"Mom, I'm at work and I'll be free at seven. Would it work for you if I called then?"
Mom	"Well, excuse me for wanting to talk to my own child."
You	"I want to talk to you too, Mom. Just not while I'm rushing around. Does seven work?"

At seven that evening:

Mom	"Finally. You couldn't find even five minutes during the day?"
You	"Mom, why don't we agree on which days I'll call? The kids have activities on Tuesday and Friday evenings, so I could talk to you without rushing while they're there. Would that work for you?"
Mom	"Well, imagine that. Your own mother has to make an appointment!"

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You "Mom, think about which evenings work best for you. Let's talk on Friday and figure it out. Love you."

Say goodbye warmly, and don't keep arguing. Be sure to call on Friday as promised, in your normal voice. It's easier for Mom to wait when she knows the call really will happen.

When Mom is in a good mood: If she asks how you're doing and listens to your whole answer, say, "Mom, I really enjoyed talking with you."

♥ WHAT MOM COULD SAY OR TEXT INSTEAD

✓ **Mom:** "Sweetheart, call me when you have a chance. I've missed you. I'm going to the theater Wednesday evening, but otherwise I'd love to hear from you." Moms, remember: a call that leaves your daughter feeling good is one she'll want to repeat. A call full of reproaches is one she'll put off.

♥ **You don't have to be available to your mom all the time. Even if you're just relaxing or don't feel like talking, that's reason enough not to pick up. Your love for your mom isn't measured by whether she can reach you at any hour of the day or night. But make sure her phone has an SOS emergency-call function set up, and teach her how to use it if she's in trouble and needs emergency help.**

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1.3 When Mom Complains That Your Calls Are Too Short

You have five to ten minutes to talk to Mom. You answer her call but explain that you only have a few minutes.

WHAT MOM SAYS

"Fine, fine, I'll call later. I won't keep you. Your mother always comes last."

"I didn't expect you to have more than five minutes for your mother anyway."

YOUR GOAL

Don't feel guilty or make excuses for how much time you can give your mom.

GO-TO PHRASES

Daughter	"Mom, I'm really glad to hear your voice. I wish everyone weren't so busy these days. It's hard to keep up with life. Tell me how you're doing."
Mom	"What can you possibly tell someone in five minutes?!"
Daughter	"I'd love to talk longer too, but right now I only have five minutes. How have you been feeling?"
Mom	"Oh, how do you think I've been feeling? Not that anyone cares but me."
Daughter	"I care a lot—you're my only mom. Tell me!"

IF MOM KEEPS BLAMING YOU

Mom	"Of course, five minutes... You have hours for strangers, but your mother gets a conversation measured with a stopwatch."
Daughter	"Mom, I think about you and worry about you all the time. I'm almost where I need to be, but I've got another couple of minutes. Want to tell me what's going on, or should I call tonight?"

♥ WHAT MOM COULD SAY INSTEAD

✓ **Mom:** "What perfect timing—I caught you when you had a minute! I've been dying to tell you some news. Listen to this..."

♥ **Even five minutes on the phone is attention and care. You don't need to feel guilty because you can't talk longer today. The length of a call isn't a measure of how much you love your mom.**

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1.4 When Mom Complains You Don't Give Her Enough Attention

WHAT MOM SAYS

"You have time for everyone except me."

"I'm last on your list."

"You can sit in a café with your girlfriends, but when it comes to visiting your mother for half an hour, suddenly you have a thousand excuses."

"Of course your mother-in-law matters more. You visit her every weekend, and I'm just an afterthought."

WHAT NOT TO SAY—AND WHY

✕ **Daughter:** "That's not true! I came over three times just last week!"

Why this doesn't help: If you start counting visits to prove your point, you'll lose at that kind of bookkeeping anyway. This isn't really about how many times you visited or called. Mom is trying to get proof that you love her, according to her own idea of what counts as love.

✕ **Daughter:** "I'd visit more often if, just once in a while, our conversations weren't all about what a terrible daughter I am—or what a terrible person my dad / brother / husband / kids are."

Why this doesn't help: It's a direct insult and an invitation to fight: "Of course! Who would want to visit such a terrible mother, one who does nothing but complain? And who else is going to tell you the truth?!"

GO-TO PHRASES

Daughter	"Mom, of course you're the most important person in my life. Tell me, what happened with Aunt Nina and...?"
Mom	"See? You visit once a month and all you're interested in is Aunt Nina. Not your own mother."
Daughter	"I was just curious about that story. So tell me, how was your book club evening?"

IF MOM KEEPS BLAMING YOU

Mom	"Other people's children visit their mothers a lot more often."
Daughter	"Mom, I'd like to come more often too. Next Thursday we're getting out of the office early. Want me to pick you up so we can go shopping together?"
Mom	"I don't need your charity. Don't bother coming at all."

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Daughter "If you change your mind, let me know by Tuesday, okay? If Thursday doesn't work for you, I'll book myself a massage instead."

♥ WHAT MOM COULD SAY INSTEAD

✓ **Mom:** "I'm so glad you found time to visit! I know how hectic life is for everyone these days, and how hard it is to find a free moment."

♥ You can love your mom and still make time for your husband, children, friends, and yourself. You don't have to keep proving who's most important. Having other people you love doesn't mean you love your mom any less.

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1.5 When Mom Complains About Her Health

WHAT MOM SAYS

"My blood pressure is dropping again. I'll have to go to the hospital. I won't have to suffer through this lonely life much longer."

"My condition has flared up because you're putting me under so much stress with your heartlessness."

"I'm this sick because I spend all my time crying over you."

"Don't worry about me. I'll be dead soon and you can all have some peace."

✕ Don't drop everything and rush to Mom every single time she says something like this. If it keeps happening, she'll learn that these words bring you over immediately, and you'll start dreading her calls.

WHAT NOT TO SAY—AND WHY

✕ **Daughter:** "Mom, here you go again."

Why this doesn't help: Mom hears that you don't believe her, and she'll try even harder—and louder—to convince you she's unwell.

✕ **Arguing that it isn't your fault:** "What does this have to do with me? The doctor said it's age-related."

Why this doesn't help: Mom wants more care and attention. When you say you aren't responsible for her health problems, what she hears is, "I'm already doing enough for you, and I'm not going to do any more."

GO-TO PHRASES

Daughter	"Mom, high blood pressure is serious. If you're feeling unwell, I'll call an ambulance right now."
Mom	"I don't need an ambulance! Just stop upsetting me with your indifference!"
Daughter	"Mom, you matter so much to me, and your health comes first. I really can't come over right now, but if you're unwell, tell me and I'll arrange for a doctor to come to you. Do you have all your medication? I can order express delivery."

Once the call ends, don't call back ten times. Send one message: "Mom, I'm here if you start feeling worse. Call anytime. Otherwise, I'll see you Wednesday. Sending you a hug."

Important: If she sounds genuinely ill, don't try to guess what's going on—call emergency services. And if Mom says she doesn't want to live or threatens to harm herself, don't take it upon yourself to

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decide whether she's serious. Contact her doctor, relatives who live near her, or emergency services.

When Mom is in a good mood: If she calls just to chat, without complaining, stay on the phone a little longer: "Mom, it's so nice that you called just to say hi."

♥ WHAT MOM COULD SAY INSTEAD

✓ **Mom:** "Hi! How are you? My blood pressure's high today, but I've decided to keep an eye on it for now rather than go straight to the doctor. I just wanted you to know, in case anything changes. How are things with you? Want to come over for lunch one day?"

♥ **You can care about your mom's health without being responsible for how she feels. Her pain and anxiety deserve attention, but you are not to blame for her illnesses.**

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2. PERSONAL SPACE

2.1 When Mom Shows Up Without Warning

The doorbell rings. You open the door and there's Mom—without any warning.

WHAT MOM SAYS

"I was passing by on my way back from the store, so I thought I'd drop off some fruit for the grandkids. Open up, these bags are heavy!"

"I don't have to announce when I'm coming over. I'm your mother."

"I was just in the neighborhood."

"I'm outside your door. Let me in."

"What, your own mother isn't allowed to come inside?"

"I won't stay long. Why are you making such a big deal out of it?"

WHAT NOT TO SAY—AND WHY

- ✕ **Daughter:** "Mom, I've asked you not to come without calling! We only just got up and we're getting ready to go out!"

Why this doesn't help: Unfortunately, when Mom is already standing on your doorstep, refusing to let her in even for five minutes is likely to go badly. It may lead to a storm of hurt feelings: "My own daughter wouldn't even let me through the door!"

- ✕ Staying quiet and pretending no one's home. It's especially unhelpful to involve your children or husband. You end up hiding in your own home, while Mom feels rejected because her daughter won't let her in.
- ✕ Letting her in, seething all day, and then unloading everything on her at once. What Mom will remember isn't your request; it's the argument.
- ✕ **Daughter:** "Mom, you're violating my personal boundaries." To Mom, these sound like buzzwords from the internet. She may get offended or laugh: "Oh, don't start lecturing me with all your fancy words!"

YOUR GOAL

Reduce unannounced visits while still treating your mom respectfully, without making her feel rejected.

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GO-TO PHRASES

Daughter "Mom! What a surprise. Come on in! I've got a work call in ten minutes—a two-hour conference—and then I'm heading out to my club meeting. My husband is taking the kids skating; he's been promising them for ages. It's too bad you didn't call ahead. We could've picked another day when everyone was free."

Mom "Are you telling me you've only got ten minutes for your own mother?!"

Daughter "I'm sorry the timing didn't work out today. If you call ahead next time, I'll try to move a few things around so we can spend longer together."

Mom "I'm your mother. My daughter's home is my home too. I don't need to call."

Daughter "Mom, I'm always happy to see you. A call just gives me a chance to rearrange my plans a little. Would you like some tea with lemon?"

Ten minutes later: "Mom, I need to get to work. Thanks for stopping by. Want me to ask John to give you a ride on his way to the skating rink?" Give her a hug and see her out.

If this happens every week: Tell her once, calmly, and not in the doorway: "Mom, I love seeing you. When you call first, though, I have time to put things aside and we can really sit and talk instead of rushing. Will you call next time?" If she keeps arriving without notice, greet her warmly but don't cancel your plans.

When Mom is in a good mood: If she calls in advance, give her an especially warm welcome: "I'm so glad you called! I got your favorite pie." Let calling ahead lead to a better visit.

♥ What Mom Could Do or Text Instead

✓ **Mom:** "Hi, sweetheart! I've really missed you. Could I stop by for a couple of hours sometime this week? I could bring my knitting, and we could have tea and catch up."

♥ **You have a right to personal space, even when it comes to your own mom. You can love her and enjoy her visits without wanting her to show up unexpectedly. Your home is where you decide when and whom to welcome. And even if Mom takes offense at your rules, that doesn't mean you have to abandon them.**

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2.2 When Mom Criticizes Your Partner or Husband

Mom disapproves of your partner and never misses an opportunity to let you know.

WHAT MOM SAYS

"Well, you sure picked yourself a man."

"He's turning you against me."

"A real man wouldn't act like that."

"Just look at you, and then look at him."

"He bosses you around. You only do what he wants."

"What would I even talk to him about? He never went to college."

"You're living in poverty because he can't earn a decent living."

WHAT NOT TO SAY—AND WHY

✕ **Daughter:** "There's nothing wrong with him! You were always criticizing Dad, so you're one to talk!"

Why this doesn't help: Defending your partner this way means attacking and dismissing your mom. It's unlikely to help build a warm, trusting relationship in your family.

✕ **Defending your partner with a list:** "He fixed the place up himself and picks the kids up from daycare." Mom will have a "yes, but" for every point, and you'll spend half an hour discussing his shortcomings.

✕ Agreeing with Mom, letting her disparage someone you love, or forbidding her from ever raising the topic. Instead, agree to discuss the specific situation that's troubling her, rather than treating your partner as a "bad person."

YOUR GOAL

Create conditions in which Mom and your partner can attend important family gatherings without arguments turning personal. Don't let her criticism determine how you feel about your partner or what you decide in your private life. But don't stand by silently when she makes demeaning remarks about him, either.

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GO-TO PHRASES

Mom "And you still want to live with him? He can't even provide for his family."

Daughter "I understand why you're worried. I'm concerned about our financial stability too. We're not just sitting around; we're working together to improve things."

IF MOM KEEPS BLAMING HIM

Mom "What did you ever see in him? Just look at you and look at him. I bet he's a womanizer too!"

Daughter "What makes you think that?" {Show Mom that her opinion matters to you and that you understand she's concerned about your well-being.}

Mom "I can see him checking out other women!"

Daughter "Mom, I haven't noticed anything like that. Dan is very attentive to me. But if it worries you, why not ask him how he feels about your daughter? You have every right to ask him those questions."

WHEN YOUR PARTNER IS PRESENT

Mom "Who puts up shelves like that?! Look at this! I told you you were all thumbs!" (to your partner)

Daughter {hugging her partner} "Mom, you asked, and we genuinely wanted to help. I told you Dan's a barber, not a carpenter. Why don't we go have tea, and tomorrow we'll call someone who can put the shelves up the way you want?"

♥ WHAT MOM COULD SAY IF SHE DOESN'T LIKE HER DAUGHTER'S PARTNER

✓ **Mom:** "I don't like Dan. I know I barely know him, but he doesn't seem dependable to me. He's too good-looking. I'm afraid he'll leave you the way my husband left me, and you'll be hurt the way I was. And since he came into your life, you've hardly had any time for me, which is another reason I don't like him. But I understand that none of this gives me the right to criticize someone you love. I'll try to make sure he doesn't feel uncomfortable around me, because he's important to you. More than anything, I want you to be happier than I was."

You don't argue about your partner, but you don't shut down the subject either. Ask once what exactly concerns Mom. If she still spends that day criticizing him, you can gently say, "Mom, let's not argue today. I'll call you tomorrow, okay?"

If she brings it up on every call: On a calm day, tell her once, speaking for yourself: "Mom, it's hard for me when every conversation turns to my husband. I'm happy with him, and I want our talks to be about you and me. If something genuinely worries you, tell me directly and I'll listen." Mom: "So he's more important to you than your mother!" — "Mom, you're both important to me. I don't want to choose between you."

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Be honest with yourself: If Mom points to something specific—your partner yells at you, hits you, or takes your money—don't brush it off. In situations like that, having someone close you can turn to for support in a crisis really matters.

When Mom is in a good mood: If she says something nice about your partner even once ("Well, his meatballs aren't bad"), tell him and say to her, "Mom, I told him what you said. He was so happy."

♥ You have the right to decide who you want to be with. Mom may have her own opinion about your partner, but you don't have to constantly defend your choice or prove that he deserves her approval. You know your own relationship better than she does. Even if she never accepts your partner, that doesn't mean you have to choose one of them. Above all, try not to let the situation turn into hurtful remarks and personal attacks.

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2.3 When Mom Interferes With How You Raise Your Children (Her Grandchildren)

Your mom lets your children—her grandchildren—do things you don't allow, such as eating sweets or playing video games. She may also criticize their hobbies and friends.

WHAT MOM SAYS

"Stop torturing that child with your strict schedule."

"At least let him eat properly when you're not around."

"Mommy's mean, but Grandma's nice."

"You'll never be a good mother."

"You've worn that poor child out with all those after-school activities and lactose-free diets. We raised you on regular milk, and you turned out perfectly fine."

WHAT NOT TO SAY—AND WHY

✕ **Arguing about parenting in front of the child:** "Mom, that's not how people raise children anymore. There are studies about this."

Why this doesn't help: Your child sees two adults fighting over them, while Mom hears that you're saying she raised you the wrong way.

✕ **Later announcing a serious talk:** "We need to discuss how you behave around the kids."

Why this doesn't help: All Mom hears is that you think she's a bad grandmother.

✕ Telling your child not to listen to Grandma.

Why this doesn't help: Your mom does have a right to be involved in her grandchild's upbringing. You don't know what the future may bring, and that alone is a reason not to turn your child against her.

YOUR GOAL

Make sure your child is safe and isn't harmed physically or emotionally, without putting down the child's grandmother.

✓ **What to do:** In front of Grandma, explain calmly and briefly to your child: "Regular milk makes your stomach hurt. You can have juice instead, or take a lactase capsule." Tell Mom what is okay and when: "Mom, regular milk really hurts his stomach. He gets gas, and his classmates can hear it. You wouldn't want them to make fun of him, would you? I'll give him a lactase capsule today, but next time, please get lactose-free milk, yogurt, and ice cream. Or I can bring those things over when I bring him."

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GO-TO PHRASES

Daughter (to her son)	"You can have the chocolate after lunch. Let's put it right here."
Mom	"You're wearing the child out with all these rules. Grandma's not even allowed to give him a treat?"
Daughter	"Of course you can, Mom. He'll have it after lunch."
Mom	"Lunch is ages away. Why are you making such a fuss over nothing? It's just a piece of chocolate."
Daughter	"Mom, afterward it's hard for Dan and me to explain to our son why something is forbidden one day but allowed the next. I'm worried he'll start thinking that rules and principles only apply when it's convenient."
Mom	"Oh, stop trying to sound so clever. You always make everything so complicated."
Daughter	"Mom, I love you, and of course you have far more experience than I do. But today we'll do things the way we do them in our family. He's Dan's child too, and before I change our rules, I need to talk it over with him."

If things get out of hand, you can end the visit earlier than planned. Gather your things calmly, without slamming doors, and hug Mom goodbye. Call her the next day in your normal voice. If your child asks why Grandma is angry, say: "Grandma is upset with me. This isn't about you. She loves you very much."

When Mom is in a good mood: Ask her advice where her experience can genuinely help: "Mom, how did you treat my colds when I was little?"

♥ WHAT MOM COULD SAY IF SHE'S UNHAPPY WITH HOW HER GRANDCHILDREN ARE BEING RAISED

✓ **Mom:** "I'm so afraid of becoming some old woman my grandson barely knows or finds interesting. But times are changing so fast that I really don't know much anymore about how children grow up today, what they enjoy, or what they're interested in. Please help me stay close to him. Let me see him more often. Tell me what he's into, what would make him happy, and what matters to him. Help me make the time we spend together enjoyable and warm, so he'll always think of his grandma with love and affection."

♥ **You have the right to decide how to raise your children, which rules to set, and what's best for them. Grandma may disagree, but that doesn't give her the right to overrule your decisions or undermine your authority in front of your children. Even if Mom is offended by your limits, that doesn't make you a bad daughter. Your first responsibility is your children's well-being, not keeping Grandma happy at all times.**

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2.4 Holiday Gifts for Your Children (Her Grandchildren)

Mom buys your children gifts according to her own tastes, without asking for your input. Then she's upset when she sees the grandchildren aren't thrilled with what she chose.

WHAT MOM SAYS

"She didn't even say thank you for the dress."

"You've turned her against me."

"I spent so long looking for that toy, and nothing I buy is ever good enough for you."

WHAT NOT TO SAY—AND WHY

✕ **Explaining every detail:** "It's itchy," "He doesn't like sweaters at all," "She doesn't like dresses with those little flowers," or "He's a person with his own tastes, even at five. You have to respect that."

Why this doesn't help: The conversation will drag on for an hour, and by the end, you'll still be accused of turning the child against Grandma and teaching disrespect for elders.

✕ Putting the sweater on your son before Grandma arrives just to make her feel better.

Why this doesn't help: Your child sees you making excuses for him, as though he'd done something wrong. You're teaching him to please the people he loves even when it goes against his own feelings and wishes.

YOUR GOAL

Make sure your child doesn't feel guilty for not meeting Grandma's expectations. At the same time, teach your child to respect older people and their life experience, without feeling obliged to agree with them.

✓ **What to do:** In a calm moment, tell your child how much Grandma loves them and how much she wanted to make them happy. Suggest making Grandma a thank-you card to show appreciation for her love and thoughtfulness. Explain that even when we don't like a gift, we don't necessarily need to tell the person who gave it and hurt their feelings. That's a common rule of politeness. But there's no need to wear something you dislike just to please someone, either.

GO-TO PHRASES

Mom	"Is she wearing the dress I gave her?"
Daughter	"Mom, unfortunately, she doesn't like blue or flowers like those. She's really into pink and Hello Kitty right now."

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Mom	"What nonsense, letting a five-year-old choose which dress she's going to wear. She's just ungrateful, exactly like you."
Daughter	"Mom, we're teaching her to appreciate it when someone genuinely thinks of her, but we don't force her to love every gift. She really is happy that you wanted to make her happy."
Mom	"Well, I won't buy her anything again if she doesn't like anything."
Daughter	"Would you like me to make an online wish list for her and keep it updated? It could have all sorts of things she's dreaming about, and that would make it so easy for you to give her a lovely surprise for any occasion."

♥ **You're not responsible for whether your children like Grandma's gifts. Children are entitled to their own tastes and feelings, even when those feelings disappoint someone else. You can appreciate your mom's desire to make her grandchildren happy without forcing the kids to pretend they're delighted or feel guilty for not meeting someone else's expectations. Grandma's disappointment over what she hoped would happen isn't your fault—or your children's.**

If Mom sent you this guide with the message, "See? This is how you're supposed to talk to your mother! And look how you behave!"

You can say or text: "Mom, thank you for sharing this. I'll make sure to read it carefully and try to remember it. I love you very much, and having a close, warm relationship with you matters to me."

Then try giving Mom a small but touching gift that will remind her of you and your family every day.

Gift Ideas

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